



MEDITATIONS

Reflections of a Roman Emperor



MARCUS AURELIUS

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Meditations

Reflections of a Roman Emperor

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Book One — On What I Received

From my grandfather, good manners and the government of my temper. From the reputation and remembrance of my father, modesty and a manly character.

From my mother, piety and a readiness to give, and abstinence not only from evil deeds but even from evil thoughts, and a simplicity in her way of living, far removed from the habits of the rich.

Whatever is well arranged by nature is well arranged for the good of the whole; and it is enough to remember this when you feel yourself troubled by things outside your own choosing.

Book Two — On the Present Hour

Begin each day by telling yourself: today I shall meet with meddling, ungrateful, insolent, and unsociable people, all of this owing to their ignorance of what is good and evil.

But I, who have seen the nature of the good that it is beautiful, and of the bad that it is ugly, cannot be injured by any of them, for none can involve me in what is degrading.

Waste no more time arguing what a good man should be. Be one, and let the hour in front of you be the whole of your concern.